



Republic of the Philippines
DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE
Regional Field Office No. 02
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Tuguegarao City, Cagayan 3500

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August 7, 2025

SECRETARY AMENAH F. PANGANDAMAN

Department of Budget and Management
Boncodin Hall, General Solano St., San Miguel, Metro Manila

Thru: SECRETARY FRANCISCO P. TIU LAUREL JR.

Department of Agriculture
Elliptical Road, Diliman, Quezon City

Subject: Endorsement for the establishment of Quirino Trading Center/Food Hub

Dear **Secretary Pangandaman:**

In line with our commitment to promote food security, strengthen agricultural value chains, and improve market access for our farmers and fisherfolk, may we respectfully endorse for your consideration and support the **establishment of the Quirino Trading Center/Food Hub** located at **Sta. Maria, Maddela, Quirino**.

This project aims to serve as a central hub for the efficient aggregation, trading, and distribution of agricultural and fishery products in the region. It is envisioned to reduce post-harvest losses, ensure fair market prices, and empower local producers by providing them direct access to institutional buyers and consumers.

We are submitting the required documents for your evaluation:

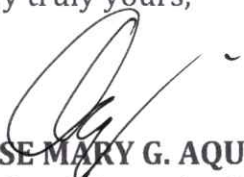
1. Feasibility Study
2. Program of Works
3. Detailed Engineering Design (DED)
4. Site Development Plan
5. Project Briefer
6. Form B
7. Budget Execution Documents (BEDs) 1, 2, and 3
8. Justification on the establishment of Quirino Trading Center/Food Hub

In view of the above, may we respectfully request the favorable consideration of this proposal under the General Appropriations Act or through any available funding mechanism from the DBM or other concerned national government agencies.

We look forward to your kind support in realizing this initiative which will greatly contribute to inclusive growth and rural development in our area.

Thank you and more power.

Very truly yours,


ROSE MARY G. AQUINO, Ph.D.
Regional Executive Director



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Environmentally, the QTC will contribute to reduced food waste and urban congestion, as bulk trading will be concentrated at the center rather than in municipal centers or roadside markets. Socially, it is expected to reduce exploitative practices by fostering a more transparent, regulated, and farmer-friendly trading environment.

In conclusion, the Quirino Trading Center is not just a response to logistical and economic inefficiencies—it is a **transformative investment** in the future of agriculture in Quirino. It aligns with the provincial government's vision of inclusive rural development, food security, and farmer empowerment, and is poised to become a key driver in elevating the province's role in the regional agri-economy. Through this initiative, Quirino takes a decisive step toward building a resilient, market-oriented, and equitable agricultural system.



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JUSTIFICATION

Agriculture remains the cornerstone of Quirino Province's economy, with thousands of farming households depending on the production and sale of crops such as banana, tomato, squash, and other high-value commodities. Despite abundant agricultural resources, the province continues to face significant barriers in maximizing the value of its produce due to the lack of structured markets, inefficient supply chains, and inadequate post-harvest infrastructure.

At present, most farmers in Quirino operate in isolation, selling their produce at the farm gate to a limited pool of local traders who often dictate prices. This practice, coupled with the absence of centralized marketing and storage facilities, has led to excessive post-harvest losses, depressed farmgate prices, and widespread farmer dependency on middlemen. The lack of access to timely market information and absence of proper trading platforms further weaken the farmers' position in the value chain.

The establishment of the **Quirino Trading Center (QTC)** is a direct response to these systemic challenges. Strategically located in **Sta. Maria, Maddela**, along the national highway, the QTC will serve as a centralized hub for aggregation, sorting, grading, packaging, cold storage, and trading of agricultural produce. By providing a permanent, organized space for market activities, the QTC will bring much-needed structure, efficiency, and fairness to the agricultural supply chain in the province.

The QTC will significantly reduce post-harvest losses by offering immediate access to cold storage and handling facilities, thereby preserving the freshness and quality of perishable goods. With modern grading and packaging areas, produce can meet the standards of institutional buyers and wider markets, expanding sales opportunities for local farmers.

More importantly, the QTC will empower farmers by shortening the value chain and reducing their reliance on traditional middlemen. Through coordinated trading systems and potential partnerships with institutional buyers, farmers will be able to negotiate better prices, participate in value-adding activities, and gain more equitable returns for their labor. With fairer pricing mechanisms, transparent market practices, and reduced transaction costs, smallholder farmers will have greater control over their income and production decisions.

The economic ripple effects of the QTC are expected to extend beyond agriculture. Improved income for farmers will stimulate rural economic activity, create new livelihoods in transport, logistics, warehousing, and processing, and potentially attract agribusiness investments into the province. The trading center will also serve as a platform for public-private partnerships, government-led extension services, and market information dissemination, further strengthening its role as an engine of inclusive development.